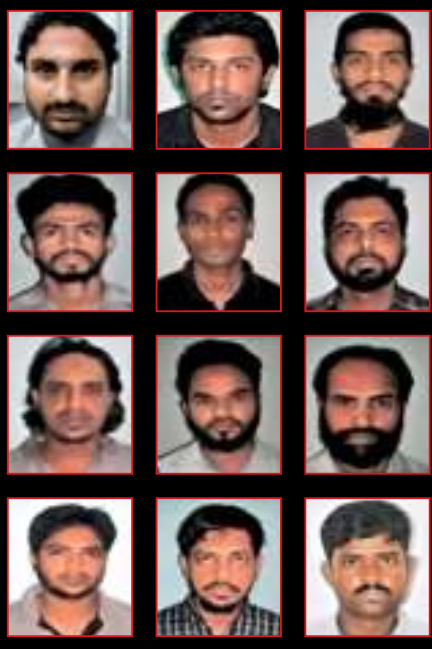
STATE SCAN

ODISHA: SHOCK & AFTERSHOCK *PG 18*

GUJARAT: THE DAY AFTER THE SKIES FELL *PG 20*





FREE TO GO The 12 accused in the 7/11 Mumbai train blasts; right, police in one of the smashed compartments, July 2006

BHASKAR PAUL

▶ MAHARASHTRA

PRESUMED GUILTY, BUT PROVEN OTHERWISE

After a plodding, 19-year legal saga, an acquittal blasts apart the flawed probe in the 2006 Mumbai train bomb attack

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT TOOK ONLY SIX MINUTES for the horror to streak through that normal evening, like staccato flashes of lightning from hell. But if evil is delivered instantly, it's proverbial in India that justice always plods along in delay—and often folly. It's been almost two decades since blasts ripped through Mumbai's arterial suburban train network in July 2006, but we are nowhere close to knowing whose hand it was. Far from bringing to them the weight of punitive law. Those who had been arraigned in the case so far were presumed guilty till proven otherwise—or rather, till nothing could be proven. On July 21, a two-judge bench of the Bombay High Court (HC) acquitted 12 accused who had, by then, spent nearly 19 years of their lives in jail.

It was on July 11, 2006, that seven blasts ripped through the first-class compartments of different local trains on the Western Railway line. The bombs, placed in pressure cookers, went off within a span of six minutes—between 18:23 hrs and 18:29 hrs—killing 187, and leaving another 827 injured.

A sprawling probe followed that had its fair share of iffy premises and false starts, ensuring the proceedings were never too far from being seen as controversial. The Anti-Terrorism Squad initially concluded the blasts were conducted by